

was born in the small city of Cremona in northern Italy in 1567. There is no evidence whatsoever of music-making in his family background, although the young Claudio must somehow have revealed a significant aptitude for music, for he was taken on as a pupil by Marcantonio Ingegneri, director of music at Cremona cathedral.

Rising through the ranks

Ingegneri was an accomplished composer in the Renaissance tradition of polyphony, in which all the parts in a work are independent and accorded equal status. By the age of 15, Monteverdi had sufficiently absorbed Ingegneri's lessons to be able to publish his own conventional three-voice compositions. He also developed into a skilled player of string instruments such as the viol.

Living in Cremona through the 1580s, Monteverdi attracted attention as a promising young composer, his published works including two books of secular madrigals. In 1590, he secured a post at the prestigious court of the duchy of Mantua. Although he was aware of Monteverdi's talent for composition, Mantua's ruler Duke Vincenzo I Gonzaga (see [box](#)) took him on as a viol player.

The composer had to work his way up through the court's musical hierarchy. He was frustrated not to be appointed Mantua's director of music on the death of the incumbent in 1596 but he nonetheless received many signs of ducal favor, as when he was chosen to lead the musicians accompanying Vincenzo to Hungary on a military expedition against the Turks in 1595. Monteverdi was joined at court by his younger brother Giulio